"Syntax knowledge offers limited value today—cognitive flexibility matters far more"

From self-taught open source contributor to Developer Evangelist at Twilio, ***Kaustav Das Modak*** shares his perspective with ***Niraj Sahay*** and ***Jiya Jay Singh*** from ***OSFY*** on the shift towards AI-driven software development, managing cognitive debt, and why open source philosophy remains the core engine of modern tech innovation.



Kaustav Das Modak,
Developer Evangelist, APJ -Twilio

Q: You entered software engineering as a self-taught developer. Looking back, how did that path change the way you approach software systems compared to someone with a formal degree in computer science?

A: Early exposure to open source completely shaped my path. At first, it was less about the broader community and more about observing how skilled engineers built complex software. Contributing to Mozilla and Firefox OS gave me access to mentors who actively guided my learning and showed me what my next contribution could be. Naturally, being a hands-on contributor led to sharing my work. I realised I enjoyed bringing other developers into the ecosystem just by talking about what we were making. That principle has stayed with me throughout my career: start by building, gather people around a shared cause, and then build more things together.

Q: Since you have worked across startups—handling static analysis at DeepSource, and now working in DevRel at Twilio—what is that one common thread in how you build and design software systems?

A: It's all about having a developer-first mindset—or what we call "wearing the customer's shoes." Developer tools shouldn't try to educate or lecture engineers; they should help them get from Point A to Point B with as little friction as possible. That customer obsession is the thread that connects all my work.

Q: Having witnessed major industry shifts—from cloud and APIs to DevOps, and now AI tools—do you see generative AI as just another productivity tool, or is it fundamentally changing how developers think?

A: It's a genuine paradigm shift. AI acts as a force multiplier: it amplifies whatever a developer is already doing—the good and the bad. It certainly helps people produce more code, but more importantly, it makes